DOJO RULES OF ETIQUETTE

1. Whenever possible it is appropriate to be on the mat ready to train at least 5 minutes prior to class starting time.

2. As you step onto the mat you should bow towards the Shomen (the front of the dojo). This is a gesture of respect to the art and its founder, and helps to shift one's awareness for proper training.

3. Jewelry should be removed before training to prevent possible injury to self and others.

4. Before class has been formally started, it is a good idea to warmup, stretch, or practice ukemi, Aiki exercises or basic Aikido techniques. Idleness and talking should be kept to a minimum.

5. Formal practice is begun when all students are seated facing the Shomen. The instructor and everyone perfumes a bow, 2 claps followed by another bow to respect for the founder of the art. Then the instructor faces the students and they bow to each other and say the Japanese word "Onegai Shimasu" (o-nay-guy-she-ma-sue) which translates as "I am in your hands", or “Let’s practice together.

6. During training there may be times when your keikogi becomes disheveled or your belt may be undone. When this happens you should turn towards the outside of the mat, i.e., towards a wall, and fix your keikogi. It is considered impolite to turn towards the Shomen or another student to fix your keikogi.

7. When working with a partner always begin with a bow and the Japanese word "Onegai Shimasu"This acknowledges each person's responsibility for safe and positive training. When finished with your training partner always bow and say "Thank you".

8. During training the instructor may come around and show you a correction or a better way of doing the technique. Pay close attention, if possible sit in “seiza” ("formal sitting position"), ask questions for clarification, and when he is finished be sure bow to say "Thank you".

9. During class it is best to sit seiza unless you have a knee or ankle injury or are not sufficiently limber to sit this way without pain in which case agura (crosslegged) is a second choice.

10. Traditionally, once class began, students were not allowed to leave the mat. However, classes at our dojo are not that strict, but it is a good idea to keep the exits from the mat area to a minimum once class has begun. Also, when leaving the mat area be sure to bow towards the Shomen and again upon your return.

11. Training ends in the same manner as it was begun. After bowing out of class students are free to move about and talk freely with one another. When leaving the mat area a bow to the Shomen is the polite way to dismiss oneself.

12. Every effort should be made to keep the dojo clean. Therefore, we have a shoes-off policy at the door and clean bare feet on the mat. Never walk from your car through the parking lot barefoot and step onto the mat.

13. Since we train in close physical contact with many fellow students, hygiene is very important. Hands should be washed before training, keikogi (training uniforms) should be frequently washed, fingernails and toenails should be kept short (to avoid inadvertently scraping or cutting your training partner), and bandaging any cuts or abrasions.

14. Please remember to show common courtesy and respect to all your training partners. We are here to study Aikido and help each other learn.

Although this may seem an extensive list of rules to remember, they will come naturally as you continue to train, each one is important to your safety and to your overall learning experience. Thank you.